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Hiring Committee
Dickinson Public Library
City of Dickinson
4403 Highway 3, Dickinson, TX 77539

Dear Hiring Committee,

I am applying for the Library Assistant position at the Dickinson Public Library. Much of what this job involves is work I already do daily. I manage a collection of printed material, handle new items as they come in, shelve and organize them, keep the records behind it accurate, and help the people who need to find something in it. That collection belongs to a fundraising department rather than a public library, and closing that gap is why I am writing.

My current title is Direct Mail Production Manager at Young Americans for Liberty, and the materials I manage are printed fundraising pieces. That means direct mail letters and their reply devices, printed proposals and reports prepared for major donors, inserts, newsletters, and the other physical outreach a development office puts in the mail. Every piece we produce ends up in a physical archive that I oversee. I take the samples in when they come back from the printer, sort and label them, shelve them by campaign and mail code, and pull them when a writer or a director needs a past piece to work from.

The part of your posting I want to answer directly is the requirement to assist patrons with library software, e-resources and public computers. When I took that archive over, nothing in it could be found without asking me, so I built the system that fixed it. I designed a SQL database for the collection, defined a consistent record for every piece covering mail code, campaign, date, format, audience and vendor, and then worked back through several campaign years of material to catalog it against that standard. On top of the database I built a searchable reading room, so staff can query the collection themselves, narrow it by any of those fields, view the scanned copy, and find where the physical original sits on the shelf. I maintain both, train new staff on them, and I am the person colleagues come to when something will not cooperate. Helping someone find what they are looking for in a system, or fix it when it breaks, is work I genuinely like.

Before this I was Development Manager at the University of Austin, where part of my work was the campus library. The university was assembling a small library largely from donated books, and I handled the intake side of it: receiving collections as they arrived, documenting what was in them, processing them onto the shelves, and recording the gift. The one I remember best was a complete set of the *Harvard Classics*. I was also the person who walked visitors through that library and answered their questions about the collection. That is the work that turned a general interest in libraries into wanting to do this for a living.

Earlier, as a student registrar at Chapman University’s Fowler School of Law, I staffed the service window as the first person students talked to, explained policies that were not obvious, and processed more than five hundred transcripts and exam records accurately and in confidence. Shelving, checking materials in and out, keeping public areas orderly, and helping at programs are all things I am ready to do from day one. Outside of work I founded the Free Knowledge Library, an archive cataloging political literature where I designed the classification scheme and built the catalog, and StateTrack, a public database of state campaign finance records covering all fifty states.

I should say plainly that I am able to relocate. I am in Austin now, and I am willing to move anywhere in Texas a position requires. Dickinson is a move I would make gladly for a full-time role in a library.

I have started the ALA’s Library Support Staff Certification and begin a Library and Information Services certificate at Central Community College in the spring, with a master’s in library and information science to follow. I am not looking for a stopgap. Thank you for your time, and I would welcome the chance to talk.

Sincerely,

Neal T. Gillespie